partisan tenets towards the Taliban. As official documents note, India's interaction with countries of the (Central Asian) region underscored a common commitment to the stability, unity, independence and territorial integrity of Afghanistan as well as a shared approach that the violation of these principles would adversely affect the entire region. Developments in Afghanistan have a direct bearing on the situation within Central Asia and their efforts to achieve political stability.[118] A forward diplomatic and military approach, entailing containment of the Taliban, became a regional norm. Regardless of internal debates between the conciliators and the partisans in context of India's own military and diplomatic capabilities, the external situation had quickly shifted in favour of the partisans.

Going against the evolving regional sentiment towards the Taliban and engaging them politically, as conciliators advocated, could have cost India diplomatic support on Kashmir from Moscow, Tehran and some, if not all, Central Asian states. This was reflected in India's active diplomacy with Kazakhstan, Turkmenistan, the Kyrgyz Republic and Tajikistan. President Narayanan visited the Kyrgyz Republic and Kazakhstan in September 1996. He was in Asthana discussing Afghanistan (among other issues) with Kazakh President Nurulsultan Nazarbaev, two days before Kabul fell to the Taliban. Nazarbaev visited India soon after in December 1996. As a result of decisions taken in these visits, India and Kazakhstan formed joint working groups on a variety of sectors including nuclear energy, hydrocarbon, and defence. Additionally, in February 1997, India, Iran and Turkmenistan signed a trilateral agreement on the international transit of goods. Similar meetings were held and agreements signed between Uzbekistan and India. The MEA stated that India maintained 'the tradition of close political understanding and mutual cooperation', and had sympathy for the efforts made to 'normalise the political situation within the country through peaceful dialogue and negotiations.'[119] Tajikistan soon allowed India to run a field hospital in Farkhor and allowed Indian journalists to cover the Afghan civil war from Tajik territory.[120] With New Delhi throwing its weight behind the UF, Tajikistan became a staging base for its covert operations.[121]